

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> Pause -> Choose one NURSE move -> Short empathy statement -> Space -> Calibrate -> Next useful move. -> N - Name the emotion lightly, with room for correction. -> U - Show partial understanding without claiming to understand it all. -> R - Respect a specific effort, value or care the person has shown. -> S - Offer realistic support, not vague rescue. -> E - Explore the meaning, need or story behind the emotion.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

It sounds really frustrating. Tell me more about what has been hardest about it.

BEST FOR

- Visible frustration, fear, disappointment, grief, anger or shame
- Complaint handling and customer escalation
- Team tension and difficult feedback
- Family stress and healthcare-style conversations
- Moments where facts alone would sound cold
- Written replies that need a short acknowledgement before the answer

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short, drop-in acknowledgements

- "That sounds really rough."
- "That sounds really heavy."
- "This seems exhausting."
- "That sounds stressful."
- "I hear you."
- "That is a lot to carry."
- "I can see this matters to you."

Naming the feeling · Name it lightly (N)

- "It sounds like this has been really frustrating."
- "I am hearing a lot of worry in this."
- "I may be wrong, but it sounds disappointing."
- "It sounds scary not to have a clear answer yet."
- "You sound worn down by this."
- "There is real weight in what you are saying."

Understanding & respect · Show it makes sense; respect the effort (U · R)

- "I can see why that would feel like a lot."
- "That helps me understand why this matters."
- "Given what happened, it makes sense that you would want clarity."
- "No wonder this has been sitting with you."
- "You have clearly been trying to handle this carefully."
- "I respect how much thought you have put into this."
- "It is clear you care about getting this right."

Support & explore · Offer real support, then open it up (S · E)

- "I can help you work through the next step."

- "I will be direct about what I can and cannot do."
- "I am not going to leave you guessing."
- "I can stay with this and help work out what happens next."
- "Tell me more about what feels most important right now."
- "What part of this is weighing on you most?"
- "What would help me understand the concern better?"
- "Tell me what part matters most, and we will start there."

At work · Meetings, complaints, decisions

- "I can see this has created pressure for you. Let me understand the main concern before we decide the next step."
- "I can see why this delay is frustrating. Here is what I can do today."
- "That sounds stressful, especially after the work you have already put in. Tell me what needs attention first."
- "I can walk through what I know and what I do not know, but first, what is the biggest question on your mind?"
- "I respect that you are trying to protect the outcome. Let me understand the concern before I respond."
- "Before we get into the fix, I want to make sure I have the main issue right."

Softening & correcting · When the empathy misfires

- "I may have named that wrong. What is the better word for it?"
- "That came out too formulaic. Plainly: I can see this matters."
- "I should not have said I understand exactly. I want to listen better."
- "Let me be more concrete about what I can and cannot do."
- "I do not want to push past what you are saying. Let me slow down."
- "Would it help more if I just answered directly now?"

Urgency & high pressure · When speed or safety comes first

- "I hear the urgency. I am going to focus on the next safe step now."
- "I can see this is serious. Let me acknowledge it, then move us to what is safest."
- "This clearly matters a great deal. I want to get the immediate thing right first."
- "I am not going to talk over how big this feels. Here is the one thing we do next."
- "I can see how much pressure you are under. Let me be quick and clear."
- "Let me acknowledge this properly, and then act on it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Calm down, I understand." Dismisses the feeling, overclaims understanding and asks them to regulate for your comfort.

Better: "It sounds like this has been frustrating." Names the emotion without arguing or fixing.

Best: "It sounds like this has been frustrating, especially after you tried to handle it carefully. Tell me what part matters most now." Names, respects the effort and explores the current need.

2. Weak: "You're amazing, honestly." Generic praise that could be aimed at anyone.

Better: "I can tell you've put work into this." Closer, but still vague.

Best: "You kept chasing this for a week and kept notes on every call. That took real effort." Respect anchored to something specific and real.

3. Weak: "Here's what you should do." Jumps to a fix before the person feels heard.

Better: "That sounds hard. Have you tried X?" Acknowledges, then still rushes the solution.

Best: "That sounds hard. Before I suggest anything, what part is weighing on you most?" Acknowledges, then explores the real concern first.

DECISION TREE

If Immediate risk or emergency

Move to safety first; use only a brief acknowledgement, not full exploration.

"I can see this is serious. Let us deal with the safe next step right now."

If Visibly emotional, and you can name it safely

Lead with one low-intensity Naming statement before you explain anything.

"It sounds like this has been really frustrating."

If Naming might be wrong or intrusive

Use Understanding instead of a label.

"I can see why this matters."

If They have clearly been trying hard

Respect a specific effort or value, not generic praise.

"You have clearly been trying to handle this carefully."

If They need reassurance about your role

Offer realistic Support with a concrete commitment.

"I will be direct about what I can and cannot do."

If They correct your label or ask for facts

Take the correction, or answer directly — stop empathising at them.

"Fair enough — what is the better word for it? And here is the straight answer."

SCENARIOS

Customer complaint

Acknowledge the frustration and the effort already spent, then be clear about what you can do now. — "I can see why this delay is frustrating. You've already spent time chasing it — I can check the status now and be clear about what I can do today."

Manager hearing bad news from a team member

Name the stress, respect the work done, then ask what needs attention first. — "That sounds stressful, especially after the work you've already put in. Tell me what part needs attention first."

Friend in distress

Stay present and warm; explore what is hardest rather than reaching for a fix. — "That sounds really heavy. I'm here with you — what feels hardest right now?"

Healthcare-style family conversation

Name the fear of uncertainty, then offer to share what is known and unknown. — "It sounds scary not to have a clear answer yet. I can explain what we know and what we're still checking."

Disagreement

Respect the value they're protecting, then understand the concern before responding. — "I can see this matters to you. I respect that you're trying to protect the outcome — let me understand the concern before I respond."

Heated digital message

Acknowledge in one line, signal that a real answer is coming, then check the main concern. — "I can see why this is frustrating. I want to answer directly, but first I want to make sure I understand the main concern."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Immediate physical safety or an emergency comes first
- The person has asked for a direct factual answer
- The emotion label would be speculative or intrusive
- You are too activated to speak respectfully
- A clear boundary is needed before any empathy
- You would be using warmth to pressure, extract or sell

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Cue spotting

List five emotional cues you tend to miss — clipped answers, repetition, silence, sarcasm, fast speech, tearfulness, a strained voice — and note where you saw each one today.

Day 2 — One letter at a time

For three of those cues, write one Naming statement, one Understanding statement and one Exploring question.

Day 3 — Compress

Rewrite each response until it is a single sentence under fifteen words, plain enough to say out loud.

Day 4 — Name lightly

Practise lowering the intensity of every label — turn "you're furious" into "this sounds frustrating" — and leave room for correction.

Day 5 — Recover from a miss

Deliberately choose the wrong emotion label, then repair it without defensiveness: "I may have named that badly — what's the better word?"

Day 6 — Make support real

Take three vague reassurances and rewrite each as a concrete offer of what you can and cannot actually do.

Day 7 — Chain it live

In one real conversation, follow a single NURSE statement with a summary check or an ask-tell-ask move, then stop and let them respond.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the emotion before I started explaining?
- Did I choose one or two NURSE moves instead of reciting the whole acronym?
- Did I name the emotion lightly enough to allow correction?
- Was my respect specific and real, and my support something I can actually deliver?
- Did my exploring question open the concern, or feel like interrogation?
- Did I know when to stop empathising and move to the next practical step?